

How do you Start a Band? (excerpt)

Confucius is rumoured to have said “A journey of a thousand miles, starts with a single step”. While this is profound and ultimately true, I bet Confucius never hung around with people who “couldn’t be arsed” or didn’t know what he was talking about. I bet he even knew where he was going and maybe even who wanted to go with him.

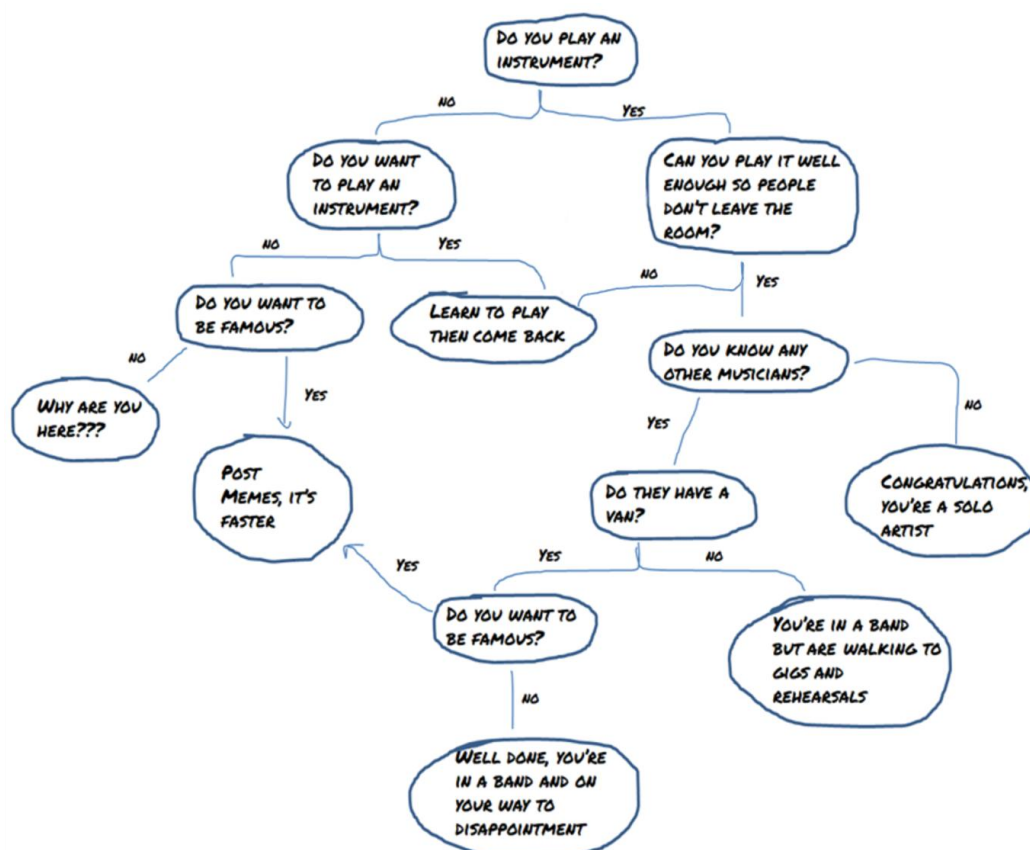
Being in a band is nothing like that, except that it has to begin somewhere. Starting a band is the first step towards your ten point plan of becoming a global megastar laced with Fender endorsements and more groupies than you’ve had hot dinners. We’ve all seen the excess of the 1980s with Motley Crue and Guns ‘n’ Roses just going nuts in dark seedy bars with more tits than your average Pornhub content. Yes please, let’s have some of that.

How do you go from bedroom rockstar — neck tie round your head, swinging your guitar and narrowly avoiding smashing your TV — to global icon and poster boy for a national guitar magazine? Firstly, you’ll need some like minded individuals to share your enthusiasm and passion. Even if burying your face in as much cleavage as possible isn’t your end goal, you’ll more than likely have thought about big houses and a flash car. Your instrument (the musical one not the other one that takes over when you’re drunk and makes poor decisions for you) is the way to get that, apparently.

Where do you start? Well, assuming you are of a respectable level on your chosen instrument, the obvious place to begin is with your friends. You already get on well with them, right? What better way to cement your friendship than rocking all over the world playing Wembley Stadium in London or the Budokan in Japan, iconic venues shared with your best mates, what could be better than that? Now think of the number of friends you

have; real friends, genuine people you can stand to be around for a few hours at least and not want to punch them. Now, how many like the same music as you? How many of them play an instrument? You might be left with one if you're lucky (or if you're Dream Theater, you've managed to make friends with people who just so happen to all play different instruments incredibly well). Now, you need to convince them that this is a good idea. They can skip double History to work on your next song — honestly; you won't need to know facts about the Battle of Hastings where we're going!

Next, you have to think about whether they have a van, all bands have a van don't they? What else do you need to think of? I've designed a flow chart below to help you get through the early stages of forming a band



I remember my first venture into a band; in hindsight I was probably quite lucky. As I mentioned I shared a bedroom with my brother and every Monday his mate from university

would come round and we'd jam, play some music and talk shit. My brother and his mate tried to form bands and it just wasn't working, his mate asked me if I wanted to come down one Sunday to jam with him and another one of his friends. I think my brother was put out, but without blowing my own trumpet I had become a better guitarist than him and I think his friend knew it too.

QUEST FOR THE UNICORN

So, the Sunday came around and he picked me up in his Mini Metro (not a van – are you sure we're going to a studio?) and we went down to a battered studio in the centre of Middlesbrough, where I was told that one of his mates would be coming too. I went down the stairs and managed to push the door open to find that his mate was already in there.

So there we were the three of us, the guy who brought me played bass, I had my guitar and the other guy also had a guitar. There was no drummer and the singer (who was female) had quit the week before. Not a band as such but I guess it was a start.

Right, what now? We started jamming to some songs that the bass player had written from the time he was in another band, this wasn't like in the movies where it's all great, it was three people playing different things and thinking it was cool. The other guitarist suggested that he would pick up the vocals temporarily whilst we looked for a new singer — he's still singing now, so obviously that search went well!

The bassist started to take over proceedings and thought of himself as the most important member, he's been in bands before and knows "how they work". I was new to all this and no idea what was going on, and the newly appointed singer was wondering what he

was doing here. So we let him take charge, eventually coming to the conclusion that we were missing a set of drums and someone who knew how to play them, although I think we'd all thought that about thirty seconds after opening the door.

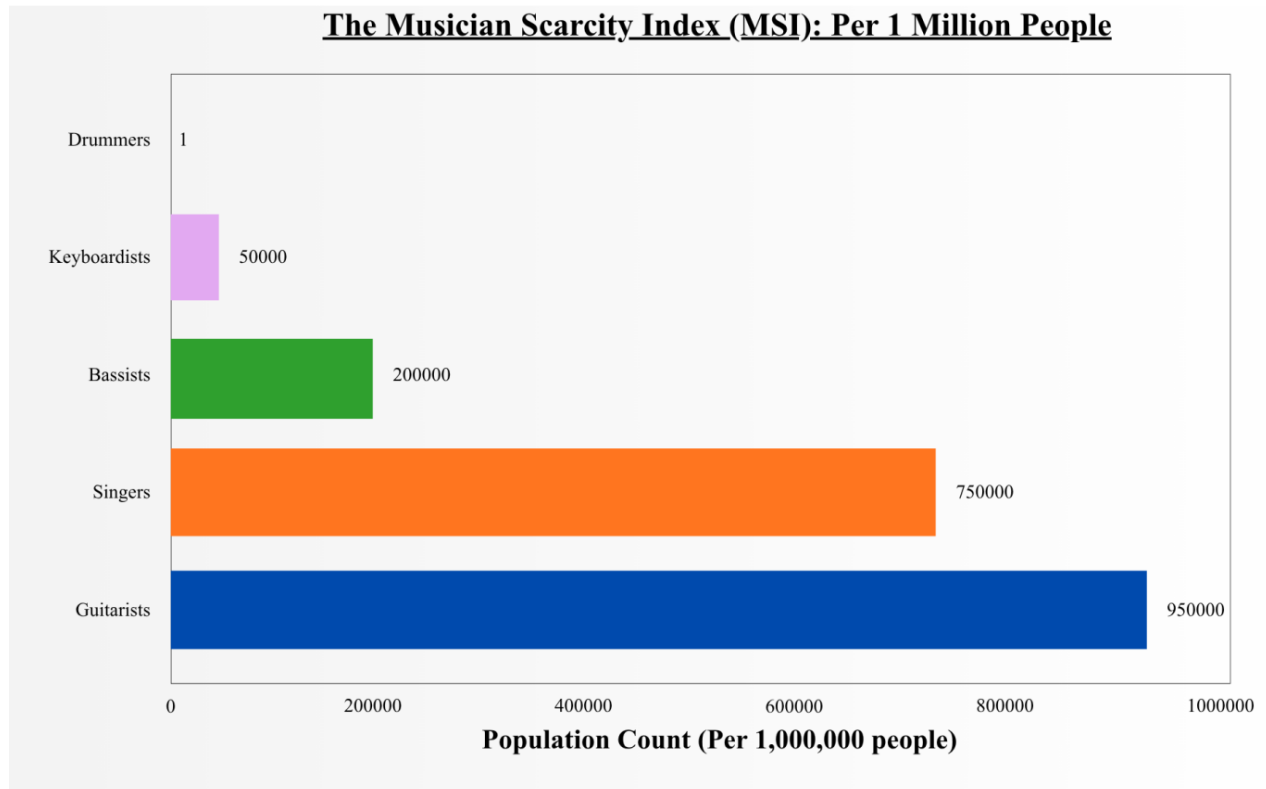
Drummers are rare, and good reliable ones are like rocking horse shit. Where do you even start with getting one in? Do they all hang about together in some dark club somewhere and talk about bass drums and what types of sticks they use? Do they have t-shirts that explicitly mention they hit things in a rhythmical fashion? All of this was before social media, so where do you advertise if you are even going to go down that route?

The most obvious place to look is the 'circle of friends', there are three of us and our circle was a little wider now, still no one though. Drum kits are big and noisy, most parents will have laughed hard when their child asked for a drum kit for Christmas and persuaded them to take up something a bit quieter. We asked if the bass player could potentially poach the drummer from his last band. I don't care if his timing is off, he has a kit and can play more than one thing at a time, for the purposes of getting us on the road to infamy this will do. Hey, we can always chuck him for a better model once the cash rolls in, right?

Sadly we had no joy, he turned us down. How can this be though? Does he not know that we are going to be the best band ever? We have no proof and nothing to show for it, but we play instruments and everyone is obviously worse than us, so it makes no sense to turn us down, but ok, maybe we should start to refine what our actual goals and ambitions are and set more realistic targets.

Funnily enough, when I was thinking about barriers to fame, not being able to get a drummer in was not something I had considered. It was more about how do I get to Heathrow Airport for our tour of America? Or how do you deal with so many bookings that you'll probably have to disappoint some fans.

Our search for a drummer was farcical, comical even, I never considered how rare they are. Over the years you get to know more about how things work and you increasingly see that people who play certain instruments are like hen's teeth. Searching for them is like El Dorado; both in how legendary it is and the gold waiting for you if you get it right. I've termed this the Musician Scarcity Index (MSI) as illustrated below:



As you can see guitarists are “ten a penny”, there are loads of them. It's rare that anyone will put out an advert for a guitarist, unless it's a niche genre or you're looking for a virtuoso in a town of three chord wonders. If you want to be in a band, then you and your Gibson Les Paul (look at you with your posh guitar) will probably need to start from scratch and look for the rest of the members; taking into account the MSI for clear direction of how achievable each one is. Failing that, you can just become a solo artist, grab a loop pedal and annoy people in cafes and open mic nights instead.

Singers fall into three categories, the wild front person who stands close to the edge of the stage, clutches the microphone or stand (or both) and waves it around like a medieval mace. The failed “Britain’s Got Talent” one, who thinks they’re the best because that’s what their mum told them, and is only really interested in singing the theme from The Bodyguard or Alannah Miles’ greatest hits. Finally, there’s the singer that really didn’t want to be a singer, can hold a tune, but hates being the centre of attention.

Bassists call themselves “The Glue” and fall into two categories, the first is the failed guitarist, the one who wanted to be in a band but found out that everyone else who played the guitar is better than they are. They stick to basic notes and rarely look to play anything outside of the root. Then there’s the second lot who actually play bass and not just root notes. They add dynamics to the songs, sure, but they tend to noodle a lot, drift out of time with the drummer and blame them for not keeping up. I’ll be honest here and say that most bassists I’ve come across fall into the first category, they’ve seen the MSI and decided to reduce the amount of strings they play with. In the early days of forming a band this is fine, but as we’ve started to write better songs, this has become a limiting factor.

Keyboard players have zero interest in anything with strings, but they crave the same attention. Usually trying to not just blend into the smoked background and be part of the stage design, they are more flamboyant and quite vocal in musical direction. They may even sport a keytar — a curious instrument that is essentially a keyboard slung over their neck and played like a guitar — to enable them to move around a bit more. I’ve only ever played with one keyboard player and found that I competed a lot for centre stage behind the singer, which I personally found to be really tough.

Drummers, however, are the rarest of them all, an endangered species that the lions circle with interest. Once a drummer posts he’s looking for a band they all come out and

there are offers all over the place, it's like walking past a load of restaurants in Gran Canaria when they're all trying to push you into their establishment. It's not uncommon for drummers to be in half a dozen bands just because they have that choice, it'd be like being the only male lion in a cage of females, pick what you want, when you want, or why not have them all?

As for types of drummers, there are the ones who think that playing fast and doing drum rolls in the dark makes them good, and then the ones who treat every element as a separate instrument — turning snares and toms into a rhythmical earthquake, rather than someone who just can't quite count to five.

When I started a band, I didn't really care what level of drummer we got — we just wanted someone who had a kit and some sticks. So with the MSI being so low for them, how would we ever get one? We had asked friends and had done all that we knew (which admittedly wasn't loads). I mean I thought we'd have to strap a drum kit to an industrial light and shine it into the air in the hope that some percussion-wielding vigilante saw the call and came sliding down a rope in a bid to rescue us.

We were getting desperate; forget age, forget refinement, if they had a pulse (even a faint one) then they could be auditioned or, to hell with it, they could just come straight in. Then one day our singer said that he'd found one. Halle-fucking-lujah, it doesn't matter if he's got a peg leg and drums with his face, a drummer is a drummer and you don't turn them down. Thank the Gods of all that is rhythmical, tell us, how did you find this 'unicorn'? At a school performance!!! Yeah, that's right, all the adult drummers of Teesside must have been wiped out in the great drumming plague of 1998 and only the ones that attended assembly that year were left.

What do we do here? We're in our late teens and early twenties and he's still working out his timetable for this term. Do we need to ask permission? Consent form? DBS check? What time does he have to be back — is he even allowed out if he hasn't done his homework? I know I said forget age, but did I mean it? The age gap wasn't massive and indeed I've since been in bands with a bigger one, but it was the fact that he was so young and we probably came across as three nonces, which probably didn't look great.

I never asked our singer how he approached him without looking like he was grooming him, but whatever he did was obviously fine, definitely not enough to be put on a register. Still, we got him down to the rehearsal room (not on a school night) and although he was rough around the edges we made it work for us. This did mean though that world domination was on hold. He was raw, everything was a million miles an hour, we didn't have a click track (what's one of them?), and we just followed the tempo of a fifteen year old whose sole aim was to get to the end of the song in record time. Our style changed accordingly and our music went from more rock to more punk, with edgy lyrics to boot. Whatever, we weren't going to fire him, where would we get another drummer?

I said earlier that I was pretty lucky, and in a way I was. We kinda fell into each of the elements and although it was definitely not how I envisaged, it worked and that was us settled for a few years. However, once you have your settled line up, you need to then come up with a name, it needs to reflect your style and sound good, for me, this is almost as hard as finding a drummer.

Oh God a name! If there's a part of being in a band I hate, then it's this with endless arguments, back and forth. I've never been a big fan of names with "The" in the title; it's too indie for me and although I didn't mind indie it wasn't the musical direction I wanted to go. This was really the only input I ever had in band names, anything but a "The...". On the

other hand you can't call yourself 'Throat Ripper' if you're just a bog standard rock band with a drummer that has probably been eating skittles all day and filled with e numbers.

Remember this is the brand, your big seller, it'll be on your t-shirts and printed on fliers, as much as we couldn't go for 'Throat Ripper' (not that we would) we equally couldn't use ones like 'Magic Pink Fairy Dust' — no one is going to that show.

There were cultural references that probably would have disappeared in a few months, along with cringey names. I remember we once played with a band called 'MILF' obviously named after the 1999 movie, American Pie, it was cringe factor ten, such a terrible name, it doesn't matter whether they were actually talented or not.

Most of the time the Holy Grail of names just doesn't come and in the end someone will compromise, we eventually settled on Cellar Door, which I think lasted a few weeks until we saw that a TV company was also called that, cue more discussions until we eventually changed it to Twin Shine.

It was a big compromise, huge in fact. There wasn't anything empowering about it, it was vanilla. Bland. The type that your mum paints her living room walls in because she likes things neutral. Hey, it was a name and it wasn't either too hardcore or too soft. There were no obscure Icelandic death metal bands with the same name or TV companies either, so we were safe there too. I had no desire to object to this name and it was something, I guess. We could now move on with focussing on the music, isn't that the main reason why we're here?

So we had our vanilla identity, compromised rhythm section and temporary (but permanent) singer. We continued this way for a number of years until the Gods of Rock and Time decided that we'd overstayed our welcome and sought to kill our dreams.

Firstly, the drummer was now eighteen; skittles and e numbers were replaced with alcohol and girls, neither of which calmed him down. The party was good and we celebrated his final move into manhood, but with it came a fresh challenge, he was no longer at the mercy of assemblies and school bells. His non-rock ambitions took over and he was accepted into University.

This is our dream though, we were going to conquer the world, how can you give up on this? Instead he would be conquering the bars of London and black cabs. Short of chaining him to his drum kit, our ‘unicorn’ had grown up and turned into a Pegasus. Flying as far away from the Teesside smog as he could and straight into crowded streets and overpriced pizza, taking our dreams of stardom (and his drums) with him. I’m not sure he ever played in another band again; we probably put him off with our lack of song-writing and gigs in Doctor Browns every five months.

We were back to a band of three, where we had started. Still wanting to make this work, we decided to soldier on, roll up our sleeves and fight against the Musician Scarcity Index once more. Before long however, we struck gold — my boss’ sister! Hey, she can drum and we’d just lost one of those types to the Big Smoke, we got her in and we were up and running again.

A few months and gigs later and it was all over for her. She didn’t really take to it and in truth it never felt like it had been in the “good old days of a few months ago”. In hindsight, maybe having a female in the band wasn’t a good idea after what happened with the original singer, so off she went to do whatever it was that wasn’t to help us break out of Teesside.

Once again for the third time we were drummer-less, with less options and choices than ever before. Not for long though, the bassist saw the writing on the wall, he had got his

telescope out and spied the desolate landscape of “Drummer Island”, had become weary and didn’t enjoy playing his root notes anymore. Likewise with the drummer, I don’t think he ever picked up his instrument again to play in front of a crowd.

This left me and the singer in a metaphorical room surrounded by discarded beer cans and mic stands. Staring at the dust encrusted carpet, which surrounded a hole where a drum kit used to reside. What do we do now? We could of course go back to the Musician Scarcity Index and navigate our way through that minefield again, but the thought of that was frankly exhausting. Two of the hardest instruments to recruit had evaporated, plus there weren’t any drummers left, were there?

Where do we go from here? We eyed up our acoustic guitars; untouched and not needed for many years — resuscitated, they could be the next step. In terms of forming a band, this was probably about as straightforward as it will ever get, two people, two guitars, one microphone and a few cables. We were more flexible than a Russian gymnast and more portable than a small pencil case.

A new name was required though; Twin Shine was associated with fast, cranked, distorted punk rock with bits of twiddly lead guitar thrown in. This was going to be chilled out, an almost lounge-like experience; using the same name didn’t fit the brief and the expectations that came with it just didn’t seem to align.

Obviously we’d been down this road before, names are my enemy. I get more blocked up than a Glastonbury Portaloo and names other people came up with were usually crap, but we still needed one. With the memories of naming Twin Shine still relatively fresh, neither of us were up for hours of back and forth arguments. We agreed that his forename and my surname pushed together, it sounded more highbrow and possibly acceptable to get us some gigs as an acoustic duo.

With no songs written specifically for acoustic guitars we attempted to use the punk-fuelled high energy almost adolescent songs from Twin Shine. We tried to make it work, oh God we tried, but it sounded like a bag of spoons falling down the stairs into a dustbin. It didn't work, not even in the slightest, and we accepted that we had to write material specifically for acoustic guitars.

The acoustic project though, was probably always a stop gap; it was vitally needed at a time when we were at a low point. Sometimes you form a band to give yourself an outlet, whether that be creative or mental and I've certainly found that over the years that it's helped me cope with various things going on. I'm not the world's best socialite but I know I need some kind of social interaction, we both had a great time doing this, bouncing around all over Teesside playing our chilled out tunes.

In truth however, we always knew that one day we would need to get back to praying to the God of Rock. Once again playing the hallowed distorted music of our dark overlord, but regardless, we'd learnt loads and this time we swore that we'd do it differently.

BACK ON TRACK?

The acoustic project was minimal effort and easy to manage, as far as being in a band goes I would say it's by far the least stressful/annoyance project that I've done. Yet, one day we'd just finished a gig for one of the singer's mates in a pub in Middlesbrough town centre and he introduced himself to me to say thanks for playing and he appreciated it. We chatted and got on well and I added him as a friend on MySpace.

I had a good nose around on his page and noticed that his hobbies were "drumming and booze" — interesting, very interesting. A drummer? Right here in front of my face. He'd never mentioned it, there was no t-shirt saying how he liked to hit things either, the only

clue was this one line on his profile. A few texts back and forth and the heavens aligned, he was interested in meeting up and having a jam!

To get back on the road to rock stardom again after stopping off at the services for a few years was unbelievable, I was more excited than a five year old on his way to Legoland. I could blow off the massive pile of dust that had gathered on my amplifier and go back to raising Hell (not that we raised Hell before, maybe just one or two eyebrows). No need to send up the Bat Signal this time, the Musician Scarcity Index must have taken some time off and we were making full use of it.

Armed with a fully functioning, non-school attending actual adult behind the kit we were on our way to being a band again. We had secured the hardest one to find, already packaged up, the one that legends are spoken about and few ever get to see in the flesh. We had the drummer, but sadly no bassist.....yet. The ones that like to give it the big one about being the glue that holds the band together. The link between guitar and drums; we still needed a four stringed thumb-whapper to join our merry band of noise makers; once again the MSI went on holiday and our luck was about to change.

We could have gone back to trawling through adverts and trying to poach one from an ‘inferior’ band, but really we just needed a few pints and a packet of crisps. This one just seemed to like getting drunk and the inhibitions came crashing down. Verbal diarrhoea came spewing forth from a friend’s mouth one drunken night out. Like someone confessing his sins to a priest, he admitted amongst the drool and incoherent babbling that he played bass – wait a minute — WHAT? How could we not know this valuable piece of information? I’d known him for a few years, hiding in plain sight in the jungle of talentless chancers, we were thrown a lifejacket of hope.

So, here we are once again, after some forensic MySpace examinations and a Friday night drunken confession, we had a band, but no name. Urgh, names, here we go again, with four voices all shouting random suggestions out. We were obviously going have to ditch the acoustic tag, but this time no vanilla names and no compromise. We all wanted to rock and we were actually good musicians, the name had to be meaningful.

Inspiration can come from any avenue at any time, this one hit our bass player in the face during a stoned watch of Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas (I mean how else are you supposed to watch it?). Etching itself in the stars above (and clouds of ahem...smoke) the name sang out to him 'Gods Own Prototype'; perfect. It's slightly pretentious and the right amount of grit; we added the logo of Da Vinci's 'The Vetruvian Man' and we had a brand. Our drummer categorised our songs as "Space Rock", coupled with our drug inspired name, the pieces were falling into place. Was this the line up that would take us to the top table? I mean what could possibly stop us?

Now, if we circle back to why you got into this industry in the first place it's nearly always money or girls (speaking solely as a man, there are girls in rock bands too I know). Once you see the back of your teens though, it's usually money, mainly because you have none. When you're in your third band or one for a long time you become a bit more aware of this. You look around to take stock of where you are against these ambitions. I mean it's natural; you gotta make sure that you're still on course against your targets. So when you're in your mid to late twenties and you have neither of those things, then perhaps you need to reassess what you can do and either accept it or change something.

Thinking of this, and after a few years of gigging with our original tunes with "God's", the drummer had had enough and although he didn't want to leave, he wanted money. Something he just wasn't getting from our handful of gigs a year, playing stuff that

no one knew. For those that have done it, you'll know that at grassroots level, money isn't a thing; we have been paid in beer tokens, free food and we even got a crate of beer one time (that most of our friends drank); what you don't tend to get is cold hard cash. It happens but it's rare, it would be like paying an electrician in just cups of tea for rewiring your home. It's a massive contentious issue in the unsigned scene and huge arguments and debates have ensued online. I believe that "Yes" musicians are like everyone else and should get paid for the hours they put in, but I also see that there just isn't the money out there to pay everyone what they are worth. And that's really sad.

Unless you're a big originals band, the money is mostly in being a cover or tribute band. If you don't know the difference; a cover band is a band that plays a collection of cover songs by any artist of any genre just to get people dancing, they're usually hired for weddings and pubs/clubs that want a safe band in. Tribute bands play songs from typically one artist only and usually go the extra mile to dress up like the band they're imitating. This is where the money is at a low level, top cover and tribute bands can get close to £1000 a night, it's not to be sniffed at and some people make a decent wage out of it.

Our drummer wanted a thick wedge of this pie, with £1000 split four ways and gigging once or twice a week, you'd have a Scrooge McDuck-sized amount of money in no time. I didn't want to do this, playing cover songs went against everything I wanted to do. The lack of creativity and the sterile feeling of just playing songs that you've not created with sparks of inspiration at 2am on a Sunday morning. However, the money was appealing and I liked the people I was in the band with, we were close knit and had good camaraderie, plus what else would I do? The Musician Scarcity Index dictates that I'd be fighting for the attention, like a wannabe contestant on The Wheel of Fortune.

So I gritted teeth and went with the consensus; we stood down the original material and moved into playing other people's tunes instead. Calling ourselves *We Are Replicants* (as a nod to the 1982 Ridley Scott film – Blade Runner) we began to load up our arsenal with cover songs.

At first we said we wouldn't do the ones everyone else does and we'd pick some obscure ones, but ultimately if you're a cover band you have to do what the audience wants, so that idea quickly vanished. The idea about doing songs in your own style went out too. People want to hear the songs as they know them. Personally I put the radio on if I want to hear mainstream hits, but hey, I'm obviously in the minority.

Make no bones about it, this was designed as a cash cow and we were ready to do what it takes to get the money rolling in. No time for morals and creative pride— before you know it, you're stood in The Merlin in front of a load of drunk people, belting out "Sex on Fire", pretending that you still have some dignity.

So "Replicants" started to bring in some money whilst my lifeforce was slowly ebbing away. However, Steve then chanced upon another gem, which would lead to the reformation of our acoustic band. However, this time we added another member, a female singer whose angelic voice would give us another dimension. I had some creative spark back and we had the freedom to do the smaller gigs again, once more Lady Luck had smiled in our favour and when I wasn't even looking we had struck gold. So now I'm creative and making money, in two bands when I struggled all this time to be in even one, life is good yeah?

Well, unfortunately not. We decided that in "Replicants" to add another member – a keyboard player and Steve happened to know one (why does he suddenly know all these musicians?), she came in and before long wanted to sing lead vocals. We then started to compromise our songs (in my opinion), as she wanted more songs to sing. The more that this

happened, the more I could feel the soul of the band dying and I began to feel like I needed to get out, this wasn't what I'd signed up to. I didn't want to do covers in the first place, our banter and friendships became strained and things weren't how I wanted it to go. Thankfully, I still had the acoustic band to fall back on, so I quit.

Our Acoustic Trio was doing okay, but cracks appeared and within no time I'd gone from two bands to none, out in limbo with a guitar strapped to my back and a pocket full of song ideas. I'll admit, I was low. Being in a band was everything to me, and I'd done it for so long that it felt like I was missing a leg, staring at a void in my life that takeaway pizza or a four-pack of San Miguel just couldn't fill. So now what? I still wanted — no, needed — to be in a band. It wasn't just the creativity; I needed that space with like-minded people, with others who shared the same passion for the music I love.

I'd never started one from scratch before though, could I even do that? I still had Steve, we contemplated the acoustic stuff again, but really the last iteration was as good as that would get, with the loss of the singer those songs just wouldn't sound the same. We got together and wrote bits, more to stay in touch than anything, but he was still in "Replicants" and another band and as such couldn't dedicate too much time for a non-existent project.

Unable to call on my circle of friends as the people I knew were either busy in bands or had quit the industry altogether — I did the unthinkable and put a post on Facebook for anyone who would bite.

I was the highest mark of the Musician Scarcity Index, a guitarist, millions of us scavenging for whatever scraps people would throw out on the streets. I had some offers, none were interesting. Most were looking for a lead guitarist in an indie band, or to play whatever I got told to, like some robotic session musician — erm, no thanks. I attended zero

auditions. This time I knew what I wanted, no “Sex on Fire”, no Keyboard dictators, music for the love of it, what I wanted to do, not what others wanted me to play.

Then, here comes Lady Luck again, I got a hit on my post from someone relatively close by – a drummer – a unicorn — wanting to know if I fancied a jam round his house. Put yourself in my shoes, you know how hard this is, to throw the line in the lake and hook a big fish, the one that is legendary but no one has managed to snag.

However, this is someone you don’t know, no mutual friends and no acquaintances of any sort, for all I know he could be the Josef Fritzl of Teesside and I’d just be thrown in his dungeon for sport with only a metronome for company. Ultimately though, he’s a drummer and worth taking a risk on, with the Musician Scarcity Index firmly chucked out of the window, I arranged to go round and nervously knocked on his door, no hint of a dungeon or any suspiciously raised flower beds.

I’d done it, snagged the drummer before anyone else. I met up with the old singer, who said his other band was done but the guitarist and bassist still wanted to do something. We all got together and we started our current iteration, no frills, no compromises, full of friends and banter, exactly how it should be. Now the part I hated, the name. Thankfully this was probably the easiest of them all. Back in the Twin Shine days when we were struggling for a name, my friend (who became the bassist in God’s Own Prototype) looked up a band name generator on the internet and found what he thought was a cool name (it didn’t fit our style). Fast forward to this band and we took it on, all done, no arguments or dramas: we were ManFrog. If you’re asking why we didn’t use this name when I was actually in a band with him, well, erm... I suppose you’d have to get him drunk and ask him yourself.

It's all luck though, a musician's game of Deal or no Deal, no skill, it's just about who you ask. No guarantees, you keep opening boxes and you just hope that the next one doesn't contain a bossy keyboard player or another drummer moving to London.